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UC-Berkeley student gov't calls on UC Regents to end nuclear weapons research at labs

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- The student senate voted Wednesday to ask the University of California Board of Regents to stop nuclear weapons research at the nation's two largest nuclear weapons research laboratories, which are run by UC.

In an 11-5 vote, the ASUC Senate approved a bill to send a letter to the regents requesting that they renegotiate their contracts "as a matter of highest priority" with Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory and Los Alamos National Laboratory and end nuclear weapons research there. The labs are contracted to UC by the U.S. Department of Energy.

"There's a problem of silence on the UC regents. They aren't explaining what's going on," said ASUC Senator Jessica Quindel, who co-authored the bill. "They are simply doing things, and it is not understood why they are maintaining these contracts."

Valerie Kao, a UC Berkeley junior who pitched the idea of the bill to senators, said students generally do not know that UC runs nuclear weapons labs. Kao said she learned about that fact earlier this year.

But UC spokesperson Jeff Garberson said it is clearly open knowledge that the two labs have been conducting nuclear weapons research.

The UC regents have been contracted by the U.S. government to manage nuclear testing facilities since the 1940s.

"I would take strong issue that it is secret," said Garberson, who had not read the senate bill.

The labs have been prominent in the media over recent controversies involving their research in nuclear weapons technology. The Los Alamos lab came under heavy scrutiny recently after a series of high-profile security breaches.

The security lapses led to the indictment of Wen Ho Lee, a Los Alamos scientist who later pleaded guilty to downloading nuclear secrets on an unsecured hard drive. Federal investigators failed to prove their initial charges that Lee was a spy for China.

There has also been ongoing controversy at the Livermore lab over construction of the National Ignition Facility, a multibillion dollar laser that will simulate the conditions of a nuclear reaction.

Garberson said the regents are open and willing to discuss the labs' contracts in a public forum, such as at a regents' meeting.

"In both cases (of the labs), the government asked them to do it, and the university has always been motivated by a sense of public service and patriotism to help when it reasonably could," Garberson said.

The labs no longer design new nuclear weapons as part of a comprehensive test ban treaty signed by President Clinton in 1996. It was never ratified by the Senate.

The treaty allocated the weapons labs more money and resources to maintain and safeguard old nuclear weapons.

While Garberson said it is possible for the university not to be involved in nuclear research, it would cause the research to be less effective because the quality of scientists and engineers would not be as high.

Earlier this year the regents extended the contract period for both nuclear weapons research labs, so it is unlikely there will be a re-evaluation of the contracts soon. The current contracts expire in 2005.

If the regents do not renegotiate their contract, the ASUC Senate will request that the regents write a letter "providing explicit evidence" as to "what interests are being served by their management of these labs, why UC cannot or will not renegotiate their contracts until expiration and how maintenance of the labs will safeguard UC Berkeley students, faculty, staff and community members from future attacks."

"This is about public information," Quindel said. "We need to understand why they are managing these labs. (The public) needs to know what the UC is involved in."

The ASUC bill alleges that "by managing the development of the U.S. nuclear weapons arsenal, the University of California is associating higher education with the creation of nuclear weapons that are immoral and illegal in accordance with international law."

Kao said she wrote the bill in light of the Sept. 11 terrorist attacks, saying nuclear weapons should not be used for a nation's defense. She added that she will present the same resolution to the faculty.

Opponents of the bill said they were unconvinced that it would affect how nuclear weapons research is conducted.

"If we stop (nuclear weapons research) here, it's going to go somewhere else," said ASUC Senator Jesse Gabriel.

Julian Borrill, a scientist at the Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory, which does not conduct nuclear weapons research, said such research is a violation of the comprehensive test ban treaty that banned nuclear testing and held nuclear states for "good faith" disarmament.

"These projects are being sold to the public as necessary to maintain nuclear weapons. But in reality, (the projects) are actually being used to make new weapons," Borrill said.

Supporters of the bill also maintain that UC has misled some of its employees into believing that their work is not being used for nuclear weapons research.

Livermore lab spokesperson Gordon Yano said it is unlikely that employees would not understand what their research is being used for. "I can't imagine that a new applicant here is unaware of the various kinds of research that is going on," he said.

Yano said the labs are not developing new weapons and that a nuclear weapon has never been on site.

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